

CRYPTID TRACKER

Solo Dev Roadmap

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Engine: Unity (C#)

Platform: iOS & Android

"One region at a time. Ship it."

Solo Dev Strategy

The Goal:

Build a complete, shippable mobile game by focusing on one fully playable region first (Sasquatch Forest), then scaling content using a data-driven architecture. Every system you build for Region 1 becomes a reusable template for Regions 2–8.

Key Principles:

- **Build the skeleton first** — get the full game loop working with placeholder art before polishing anything.
- **ScriptableObjects for all game data** — regions, creatures, evidence, equipment. Adding content should be data entry, not new code.
- **One system at a time** — don't parallel-develop. Finish investigation before starting boss encounters.
- **Playtest constantly** — if Sasquatch Forest isn't fun with grey boxes, art won't save it.
- **Commit early, commit often** — Git is your safety net.

Development Phases

Phase	Focus	Duration	Milestone
Phase 1	Project Setup & Skeleton	Week 1	Full scene flow with placeholders — tap through entire game loop
Phase 2	Core Data Architecture	Week 1–2	ScriptableObject templates for all game data types
Phase 3	Vertical Slice — Sasquatch Forest	Weeks 2–5	One fully playable region with investigation, boss encounter, scoring
Phase 4	Polish & Second Region	Weeks 5–7	UI polish, Loch Depths built from template, basic progression
Phase 5	Content Expansion	Weeks 7–10	Remaining 6 regions stamped out, skill trees, equipment upgrades
Phase 6	Backend & Social	Weeks 10–12	Firebase leaderboards, cloud saves, seasonal system
Phase 7	Testing & Launch Prep	Weeks 12–14	Beta testing, bug fixes, app store submission

Phase 1: Project Setup & Skeleton

Week 1

Project Creation:

- ☐ Create new Unity project (2022 LTS or latest LTS, 2D URP template)
- ☐ Set up Git repository (GitHub/GitLab, private)
- ☐ Initial commit with clean .gitignore for Unity
- ☐ Install packages: TextMeshPro, DOTween (free), Newtonsoft JSON

Folder Structure:

```

CryptidTracker/
├── Scenes/
│   ├── MainMenu
│   ├── WorldMap
│   ├── Investigation_Template
│   ├── BossEncounter_Template
│   └── Debrief
├── Scripts/
│   ├── Core/           (GameManager, SaveSystem, SceneLoader)
│   ├── Player/         (PlayerController, Inventory, Stats)
│   ├── Evidence/       (EvidenceManager, EvidenceTypes, QualitySystem)
│   ├── Investigation/  (ScannerTool, CameraTool, AudioRecorder)
│   ├── Boss/           (BossAI, BossPhases, ResolutionSystem)
│   ├── Progression/    (XPSystem, RankSystem, EquipmentManager)
│   ├── UI/             (HUD, Menus, ScoreScreen, Leaderboard)
│   └── Data/           (ScriptableObject definitions)
├── ScriptableObjects/
│   ├── Regions/
│   ├── Creatures/
│   ├── Equipment/
│   └── Evidence/
├── Art/
│   ├── UI/
│   ├── WorldMap/
│   ├── Regions/
│   ├── Creatures/
│   └── Effects/
├── Audio/
│   ├── Music/
│   ├── SFX/
│   └── Creatures/
└── Prefabs/

```

Scene Flow Skeleton:

- ☐ Build 5 placeholder scenes (MainMenu, WorldMap, Investigation, BossEncounter, Debrief)

- ☐ GameManager singleton — handles scene loading, game state, player data persistence
- ☐ SceneLoader — async scene transitions with simple fade
- ☐ PlayerData class — serializable class holding XP, rank, unlocked regions, inventory, reputation
- ☐ Wire all scenes together so you can tap through the full game loop in under 2 minutes

Week 1 Milestone: You can tap Play → World Map → Select Sasquatch Forest → Investigation (grey box) → Boss Encounter (choice buttons) → Debrief (score number) → Back to World Map.

Phase 2: Core Data Architecture

Week 1-2

This is the most important technical decision for a solo dev. It determines whether adding Regions 2-8 is easy or painful.

ScriptableObject Templates:

- ☐ RegionData SO — Name, biome description, difficulty tier, cryptid reference, available evidence types, unlock requirements, background art reference
- ☐ CryptidData SO — Creature name, species, stats (health, speed, aggression, intelligence), evidence thresholds (% needed for Trap/Kill/Escape), boss behavior config, lore text
- ☐ EvidenceData SO — Evidence type (footprint, audio, photo, biological, witness), rarity tier, quality range (D-S), base score value, description text, collection tool required
- ☐ EquipmentData SO — Tool name, tier, stat bonuses, unlock level, upgrade path, description

First Data Entry:

- ☐ Create Sasquatch Forest RegionData SO with all fields filled
- ☐ Create Bigfoot CryptidData SO
- ☐ Create 5 EvidenceData SOs (one per evidence category for Sasquatch Forest)
- ☐ Create 3 starter EquipmentData SOs (basic camera, basic scanner, basic audio recorder)

Why This Matters: When Sasquatch Forest works, building Loch Depths means: 1) Create new RegionData SO, 2) Create Nessie CryptidData SO, 3) Create region-specific evidence SOs, 4) Add art assets. Zero new code needed.

Phase 3: Vertical Slice — Sasquatch Forest

Weeks 2–5

This is where you make the game actually fun. Build these systems ONE AT A TIME, in this order:

INVESTIGATION PHASE (Week 2–3):

- ☐ Player movement in investigation scene (top-down or third-person — your choice)
- ☐ Evidence node prefab — interactive objects scattered in the scene
- ☐ Scanner tool UI — activates when near evidence, shows scanning animation
- ☐ Evidence collection — tap/interact to collect, assigns quality grade (D through S)
- ☐ Evidence types for Sasquatch Forest: Footprints (ground), Audio (ambient recordings), Photos (visual sightings), Biological (hair/scat samples), Witness (NPC conversations)
- ☐ Evidence HUD — counter showing collected evidence per category
- ☐ Quality factors: tool tier affects base quality, player stats add bonus, time/distance modifiers
- ☐ Investigation timer — 10–15 minute expedition session length (per GDD)

EVIDENCE BOARD (Week 3):

- ☐ Journal-style UI screen accessible from investigation
- ☐ Shows completion percentage per evidence category
- ☐ Displays quality grades for each collected piece
- ☐ Calculates overall evidence completion percentage
- ☐ Unlocks boss encounter options based on thresholds:
 - ☐ 80%+ evidence = TRAP option available (live capture, x3.0 score)
 - ☐ 50%+ evidence = KILL option available (eliminate, x1.5 score)
 - ☐ Any% = ESCAPE always available (retreat, x1.0 score)

BOSS ENCOUNTER (Week 4):

- ☐ Bigfoot encounter scene loads with cinematic intro
- ☐ Multi-phase encounter structure:
 - ☐ Phase 1: AWARENESS — creature detects player, tension builds
 - ☐ Phase 2: CONFRONTATION — active engagement
 - ☐ Phase 3: RESOLUTION — player chooses path based on unlocked options
- ☐ TRAP path: Timing-based puzzle (place trap, trigger at right moment)

- ☐ KILL path: Action combat sequence
- ☐ ESCAPE path: Stealth/chase survival (survive timer countdown)
- ☐ Outcome determines score multiplier and reputation shift

DEBRIEF & SCORING (Week 5):

- ☐ Score calculation per GDD formula:
 - ☐ Base Score = Sum of (Evidence Quality × Evidence Rarity) per piece
 - ☐ Boss Multiplier = Trap (×3.0) / Kill (×1.5) / Escape (×1.0)
 - ☐ Time Bonus = expedition speed bonus
 - ☐ Completionist Bonus = all 5 evidence categories collected = +25%
 - ☐ Final Score = (Base Score × Boss Multiplier + Time Bonus) × Completionist Multiplier
- ☐ Rating grade display (D through S)
- ☐ Reputation update (+Scientific Respect / +Notoriety / +Caution)
- ☐ Save result to PlayerData
- ☐ Return to world map

Week 5 Milestone: Sasquatch Forest is fully playable end-to-end. A player can investigate, collect evidence, face Bigfoot, make a choice, and see their score. It might look rough — that's fine. Is it FUN?

Phase 4: Polish & Second Region

Weeks 5–7

UI Polish:

- ☐ Main menu with game logo, animated background, settings
- ☐ World map with stylized art, region pins, locked/unlocked states
- ☐ Screen transitions (fade, slide, zoom-in on region select)
- ☐ Investigation HUD polish — scanner overlay, evidence popup animations
- ☐ Boss encounter UI — health bars, action prompts, cinematic camera
- ☐ Debrief screen — animated score tally, rating reveal, star ratings
- ☐ Sound effects for all interactions (tap, collect, scan, encounter phases)

Basic Progression:

- ☐ XP system — earn XP from expeditions, level up
- ☐ Tracker Rank display (Novice Tracker → Field Researcher → etc.)
- ☐ Region unlock system — complete previous region to unlock next

Second Region — Loch Depths:

- ☐ Create Loch Depths RegionData + Nessie CryptidData ScriptableObjects
- ☐ Create 5 evidence SOs specific to Loch Depths (Sonar, Photo focus per GDD)
- ☐ Build investigation scene with water/highlands environment
- ☐ Add Nessie boss encounter with unique behavior (aquatic, evasive)
- ☐ Validate that the template works — if adding Loch Depths was painful, fix architecture before continuing

Phase 5: Content Expansion

Weeks 7–10

Remaining Regions (stamp from template):

- ☐ Chupacabra Canyon — Arid canyon biome, Biological/Witness evidence focus
- ☐ Frozen Peaks — Himalayan snow, Footprints/Biological focus
- ☐ Mothman Ridge — Abandoned town, Photo/Witness focus
- ☐ Billabong Hollow — Outback wetlands, Audio/Footprints focus
- ☐ Congo Basin — Dense rainforest, Sonar/Biological focus
- ☐ Pine Barrens — Dark pine forest, Audio/Photo focus

Each region needs: 1 RegionData SO, 1 CryptidData SO, 5 EvidenceData SOs, environment art, boss behavior config.

Progression Systems:

- ☐ Skill tree implementation (3 branches from GDD):
 - ☐ Researcher: evidence quality, analysis speed, recording time
 - ☐ Survivalist: combat, stamina, escape bonuses
 - ☐ Technologist: equipment stats, upgrades, unique gadgets
- ☐ Equipment upgrade system — better cameras, scanners, tools
- ☐ Cryptid Codex — collectible encyclopedia filling with lore as you play

Phase 6–7: Backend, Testing & Launch

Phase 6 — Backend & Social (Weeks 10–12):

- ☐ Firebase project setup (Authentication, Firestore, Cloud Functions)
 - ☐ Player authentication (anonymous auth to start, optional Google/Apple sign-in)
 - ☐ Cloud save system — sync PlayerData to Firestore
 - ☐ Leaderboard system:
 - ☐ Regional rankings (per-region best scores)
 - ☐ Global rankings (all regions combined)
 - ☐ Weekly season (reset weekly)
 - ☐ Monthly season (longer competition)
 - ☐ Friend challenges (async — challenge a friend to beat your score)
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Phase 7 — Testing & Launch Prep (Weeks 12–14):

- ☐ Internal playtesting — play every region start to finish, note issues
- ☐ External beta — share TestFlight (iOS) / internal testing (Android) with friends
- ☐ Bug fixing and balance tuning (evidence thresholds, scoring, difficulty)
- ☐ Performance optimization for mobile (target devices, frame rate, memory)
- ☐ App Store assets: screenshots, app description, keywords, icon, feature graphic
- ☐ Apple App Store submission + Google Play Store submission
- ☐ Launch day checklist: leaderboard backend live, analytics tracking, crash reporting

Systems Cheat Sheet

Evidence Quality Grades:

D (Contaminated) → C (Partial) → B (Clear) → A (Pristine) → S (Exceptional)

Score Formula:

Final Score = (Base Score × Boss Multiplier + Time Bonus) × Completionist Multiplier

- Base Score = Sum of (Evidence Quality × Evidence Rarity)
- Boss Multiplier: Trap = ×3.0, Kill = ×1.5, Escape = ×1.0
- Completionist: All 5 categories collected = +25%

Boss Resolution Thresholds:

Resolution	Requirement	Multiplier	Reputation
TRAP (Live Capture)	80%+ evidence	×3.0 score	+Scientific Respect
KILL (Eliminate)	50%+ evidence	×1.5 score	+Notoriety
ESCAPE (Retreat)	Always available	×1.0 score	+Caution

Tracker Ranks:

Novice Tracker (0) → Field Researcher (5K) → Senior Investigator (15K) → Master Cryptozoologist (35K) → Legendary Tracker (75K+)

Skill Trees:

- **Researcher:** Evidence mastery, quality, analysis
- **Survivalist:** Combat, endurance, escape
- **Technologist:** Equipment, gadgets, upgrades

The 8 Regions (in difficulty order):

#	Region	Cryptid	Difficulty
1	Sasquatch Forest	Bigfoot	Beginner

2	Loch Depths	Nessie	Intermediate
3	Chupacabra Canyon	Chupacabra	Intermediate
4	Billabong Hollow	Bunyip	Intermediate
5	Frozen Peaks	Yeti	Advanced
6	Mothman Ridge	Mothman	Advanced
7	Congo Basin	Mokele-Mbembe	Expert
8	Pine Barrens	Jersey Devil	Expert

Daily Workflow

Recommended Daily Routine:

1. Pull from Git (if working on multiple machines)
2. Open your task board — pick ONE task for the session
3. Build the feature
4. Playtest immediately — does it feel right?
5. Commit with a descriptive message
6. Push to remote
7. Update your task board

Recommended Tools:

- Unity 2022 LTS (or latest LTS)
- Visual Studio / Rider for C#
- Git + GitHub/GitLab (private repo)
- Firebase (free tier — auth, Firestore, functions)
- DOTween (free Unity asset — UI animations)
- TextMeshPro (included with Unity)
- Trello or Notion (free task board)
- Audacity (free — audio editing)

Where to Find Art Assets (if going solo):

- Kenney.nl — free game assets (great placeholders)
- itch.io asset packs — affordable stylized art
- Unity Asset Store — free and paid 2D/3D assets
- AI image generation — concept art and textures

"Every shipped game started with a grey box and a dream. Build Region 1. Make it fun. Ship it."
